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A Comparative study of services offered by two IPTV providers

ACT Television

Features

Internet on TV. With the help of a remote control, customers can key in a desired website name on the keypad featured on TV to access any website. Also, viewers can watch any YouTube video on the big TV screen.

Value-added services. IRCTC enables customers to check the PNR status of their train tickets on their TV sets. Customers also have access to daily panchang on their TV sets and can play various entertaining and informative games on them as well.

True VoD. Customers can choose from an extensive library of Kannada, Tamil and Hindi films and view them instantly. They can even pause, rewind and forward these videos at their convenience.

Video search. Users can type in the desired video name in the search bar of the screen keypad and watch videos immediately.

Live shift. It lets users pause, rewind and play live TV!

Spot record. This feature lets you record one programme while watching another at the same time.

Media centre. Users can watch and even transfer videos directly from their computers to the TV. With 'My personal media,' they can store family photo albums and videos on TV.

Electronic programme guide. Shows the programme schedule for the next three days.

How a subscriber accesses the service. The services are offered via Ethernet cable to subscribers. A subscriber needs an ACT cable connection and an STB offered by ACT.

Service charge. Customers pay Rs 299 per month for 160 TV channels.

Launched in Bengaluru

Aksh Optifibre's icontrol

Features

Chill. This feature provides subscribers the facility to watch missed programmes of the last seven days at their convenience.

Cool. A feature whereby one can rewind, pause and fast forward live TV channels.

VoD. A library of more than 300 Bollywood and Hollywood films.

icontrol mall. A facility to view products, contemplate and then purchase them by cheque, cash on delivery or credit cards.

Alube. Localised video classified, where one can advertise on TV at a nominal charge.

How a subscriber accesses the service. A subscriber is provided with a separate line for running an icontrol connection from MTNL after a technical feasibility check. The modem and STB are made available by Aksh.

Service. A premium plan costs Rs 249 per month and a connoisseur plan costs Rs 299 per month.

Launched in Delhi and Mumbai

but after various industry forums expressed the need for such a policy, the government has relented. If these forums can convince the government of the fact that IPTV is an infrastructure that will immensely benefit the country and the masses, and if the government, too, decides to invest in it, then that itself will be an indicator of the growth that lies ahead for this technology.

"Once IPTV touches a critical mass population in India and people start experiencing its 'never-before' offerings, it will take off like a jungle fire. This growth cycle takes place with every new revolutionary technology," says Sahu.

The key market driver for IPTV in India will be the unflinching faith the telcos have in the technology. A

strategic long-term plan on the returns on investment has to be devised in order for IPTV to succeed in the Indian market. Furthermore, innovative and interactive services should be introduced to fulfil the changing needs of viewers. IPTV providers are of the opinion that one of the best practices to follow would be to create the ideal ecosystem to enable the technology to thrive and flourish—by forging alliances with VAS providers, content providers and various other stakeholders—be it educational institutions, healthcare service providers or government departments. Educating people about its benefits should be the priority. ●

The author is senior assistant editor at EFY